CHANCE
CLIMATE & HEALTH AFRICA NETWORK FOR COLLABORATION AND ENGAGEMENT

ARIN
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KENYA MEDICAL RESEARCH INSTITUTE
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In Search of Better Health

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CONCEPT NOTE

PAN-AFRICAN SCIENCE-POLICY CLIMATE CHANGE, ENVIRONMENTAL SUSTAINABILITY AND HEALTH CONFERENCE

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NAIROBI
21ST - 24TH OCT 2025

Theme:
Harnessing Science, Policy, and Partnerships for Environmental Sustainability and Climate-Health Resilience.

Introduction

The developing countries, particularly in the African region, are disproportionately affected by climate change and its impact on vulnerable populations. Progress in national and local health policy development requires evidence for effective investment in environmental conservation, adaptation, and mitigation. Environmental challenges such as climate change, among others, are no longer distant threats but active issues undermining a clean and healthy environment, public health, food security, and economic stability. Kenya, like many other nations, faces increased environmental perturbations, disease outbreaks (malaria, dengue, cholera), and socio-economic challenges linked to biotic and abiotic factors like rising temperatures, erratic rainfall, and anthropogenic influences. This suggests that there is an emerging urgent need to tap and translate local and global scientific evidence to inform policy development, foster knowledge exchange, and strengthen multisectoral collaboration in policy implementation.

The Ministry of Health, Ministry of Environment Climate Change and Forestry, Climate and Health African Network for Collaboration and Engagement (CHANCE), Africa Research and Impact Network (ARIN), National Environmental Management Authority (NEMA), Kenya Medical Research Institute (KEMRI) and the African Medical and Research Foundation (AMREF) Africa are partnering to host a Science-Policy Climate Change, Environment, and Health conference in Nairobi, Kenya for four days; 21st – 24th October 2025**.** The conference will target and bring together new and established transdisciplinary researchers, environmentalists, health and climate policymakers, donors, the private sector, and other stakeholders to share and synthesize the latest environment, climate, and health information, showcase environmental-climate change-health technological innovations, build capacity for science-policy translation, and share knowledge on best policy implementation practices for effective climate action, health resilience, and economic development. The conference will provide a platform to advance dialogue and amplify impact on transdisciplinary fields of environment, climate, and health. We will also invite community-led organizations to network and discuss strategies to promote environmental conservation, climate and health literacy, including the role of indigenous knowledge systems.

Together, they have greater reach and will attract a wide audience for the conference, bringing researchers, policymakers, funders, practitioners, and communities to co-create solutions and drive meaningful change. The unique value for the partnership is the extent to which continuous and sustained evidence-based dialogue in the environment, climate change, and health can be supported, including strengthening networks and collaboration among stakeholders.

The conference will build on previous events that have been a catalyst for science-policy translation. CHANCE has held three successful science-policy conferences in Pretoria, South Africa (2022), Gaborone, Botswana (2023), and Harare, Zimbabwe (2024 CHAC conference). ARIN held a successful climate and health conference in November 2024 with a strong focus on transdisciplinary research. The Ministry of Health and KEMRI have successfully hosted

three Kenya's Annual Health and Climate Change Conferences in various locations, including Nairobi (2019), Kwale (2023), and Machakos (2024). These conferences aimed to address the health challenges posed by climate change and explore strategies for building resilient health systems. The National Environment Management Authority, a principal instrument for implementing environmental policies in Kenya, has spearheaded several initiatives aimed at advancing a clean and healthy environment for Kenyans for several decades successfully. On the other hand, the Ministry of Health leads national action and policy on health matters, including the integration of climate change and health in the country.

The partnership for the preparation of the conference will leverage existing CHANCE, KEMRI, ARIN, AMREF, and NEMA resources and databases to enhance efficiency and promote a consolidated approach to science-policy translation going forward. Although this conference will focus on established Environment, Climate change, and Health research, Early Career Researchers (ECR) will be invited to attend for networking and learning purposes. This approach will distinguish the conference from ECR capacity-building-focused conferences such as the CHAC Conference, and at the same time, build momentum for such conferences biannually.

The conference provides an avenue for integrating a structured mechanism for sustained impact, designed to move beyond conference conversations to measurable actions, ensuring that commitments are tracked, knowledge is translated into policy through actionable post-conference research-policy labs, where policymakers and researchers will collaborate in a virtual environment-climate change-health labs[1]/workshops to tackle real-world implementation challenges, while also creating a lasting ecosystem of science-policy-innovation partnerships post-conferences.

1 The virtual climate-health policy labs will be interactive, evidence-based workshops designed to bridge the gap between generated scientific research and policy action in addressing climate-related health challenges. They will help facilitate ongoing dialogue and ensure that scientific findings translate into actionable strategies. These labs will leverage digital tools to facilitate dialogue, data sharing, and policy co-creation among researchers, policymakers, practitioners, and civil society. The policy labs seek to serve multiple functions: **pre-conference**, they will provide a space for stakeholder engagement, evidence synthesis, and agenda-setting; **during the conference**, they will enable real-time discussions, scenario planning, and collaborative problem-solving; and **post-conference**, they will support ongoing policy implementation, monitor progress, and foster long-term networks for climate-health advocacy. Through this, there will be enhanced participation as well as tangible policy actions stemming from the conference outcomes.

The conference will systematically track progress from past Ministry of Health, Ministry of Environment, Climate Change and Forestry, CHANCE Network, ARIN, NEMA, and KEMRI conferences, contributing to the production of evidence for mainstreaming to the Africa's State of Environment-Climate Change-Health Evidence report 2025. This conference report will be formulated by a technical working group composed of the Ministry of Health, the Ministry of Environment, Climate Change and Forestry, CHANCE Network, ARIN, NEMA, KEMRI, AMREF, and other key partner committee members who will be appointed by the partner institutions. Another key outcome will be the establishment of an Environment, Climate Change and Health Working Group to advocate for stronger integration of health in Environment Management, Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs), and COP commitments. Strengthening environment and climate-health financing and civil society alliances will be another focus, with virtual labs fostering coordination ahead of UNFCCC COP30 and COP32, UNCBD COP16, and UNCCD COP17. Additionally, the conference will shape the roadmap for other future conferences, including; Biennial National Environment Conference, CHAC 2026, and post-COP30 positioning by identifying gaps and developing an implementation plan for tracking commitments. The conference will also invite organizations whose work is aligned with the conference objectives to participate in the conference. For example, we will invite UNEP, the African Group of Negotiators (AGNs), and other innovators to host workshops on steps and skills needed to integrate environment, climate change, and health into COP negotiations.

This concept note describes the conference themes, objectives, outcomes, tracks, strategic partnerships, pre- and post- conference activities, expected outputs, and a proposed budget. We also included in annexures a brief background of partner organizations.

Conference Objectives and Outcomes

Sub-Theme (Broader areas)	**Objective**	**Outcome**
Advancing Integrated Environment, Climate Change and Health Solutions: Cutting-edge Evidence, Innovations, and Integrated Approaches Across Science and Practice	● Promote knowledge sharing on climate change and health impacts across themes and disciplines, focusing on the latest evidence and innovations to advance the African climate, environment, and health response.	● Facilitate dynamic knowledge exchange on the latest climate change and health impacts across diverse themes and disciplines, emphasizing emerging evidence, innovative methodologies, and integrated strategies to strengthen Africa's climate, environment, and health resilience. ● Conference delegates gain a comprehensive understanding of current research findings, novel research techniques, new data sources, and relevant policies

		shaping climate, environment, and health sectors. ● Leverage CAPCHA Platform as a central innovation hub that highlights pioneering solutions and catalyzes impact by supporting targeted mini-grants, fostering scalable, integrated interventions.
Strengthening Environmental, Climate Change, and Health Resilience in Africa: Co-Creating Inclusive, Evidence-Based Solutions through Policy Innovation, Financing Mechanisms, and Multi-Sectoral Action	● Provide an arena for sharing ideas through the use of case studies and best practices, and facilitate co-design of policy and practice recommendations, including innovative climate-health financing mechanisms for the African Region.	● Policymakers and stakeholders across Africa are equipped with actionable, evidence-based insights and best practices to strengthen environmental, climate, and health resilience. ● Policy recommendations integrating innovative climate-health technologies and financing mechanisms into Health National Adaptation Plans (HNAPs)
Environmental Sustainability, Circular Economy, and Green Entrepreneurship for Climate-Resilient and Healthy Societies	● Share information on Environmental sustainability, Circular Economy, and green Entrepreneurship.	● Enhanced understanding and dissemination of knowledge on Environmental Sustainability, Circular Economy, and Green Entrepreneurship, empowering stakeholders to adopt innovative, sustainable practices that build climate-resilient and healthy societies.
Building Transdisciplinary and Resilient Partnerships Across the Environment–Climate–Health Nexus	● Facilitate an enabling, interactive environment for networking and relationship building among environment, climate, and health ecosystem actors.	● Leverage CAPCHA that fosters networking and collaborative relationship-building among diverse actors across the environment, climate, and health sectors. ● Strengthen and sustain transdisciplinary partnerships that promote integrated approaches to addressing complex challenges at the environment–climate–health nexus

Proposed Conference Tracks (Submissions)

The conference will consist of **nine (9) tracks** aligned with the conference objectives and our previous conferences. All 9 tracks have a strong emphasis on co-design (transdisciplinary research) and equity, and we will ensure this is clear in the EOI review guidance. The table below outlines the proposed conference tracks.

Tracks		**Description**	**Examples of research papers.**	**Conference chairs**
Track 1	Evidence and Interventions for Infectious Diseases	As the climate shifts, so too do the patterns and risks of infectious diseases, posing new challenges for global health. Submissions should highlight innovative approaches such as predictive modelling, enhanced surveillance, early warning systems, and cross-disciplinary responses to climate-sensitive diseases.	Focus on evaluation studies. Predictive modelling or disease mapping that directly informs control measures. Climate and land use determinants of infectious disease. One Health approaches	Vincent Pagiwa, CHANCE/UB Charles Michael, Africa CDC
Track 2	Extreme Heat Risks and Management	Extreme heat is an escalating threat to public health, particularly for at-risk populations. Abstracts should explore how communities and systems are adapting, from early warning tools	Focus on evaluation studies- what works to reduce the impacts of heat. Housing interventions Nature-based solutions to	Sokhna Thiam, APHRC/CHANCE tbc

		and cooling infrastructure to safeguarding workers and strengthening public awareness during heat waves.	indoor/outdoor cooling with benefits to health and wellbeing. Evaluating climate services.	
Track 3	Transdisciplinary Approaches for Climate-Resilient Environmental and Health Systems	Health systems are on the frontlines of climate impacts, but many remain underprepared. Abstracts for this session should focus on strategies to build climate-resilient health systems, including resilient infrastructure, adaptive service delivery, workforce planning, supply chain management, and emergency preparedness in climate-vulnerable settings.	Climate-resilient strategies Coping mechanisms	Rudolf Abugnaba-Abanga, HSG,
Track 4	Nature, Ecosystems, and Sustainable Economies for Health and Wellbeing	As ecosystems degrade, so too do the services they provide that underpin human health, clean air and water, nutrition, disease regulation, and mental well-being. Healthy ecosystems and sustainable economies are foundational for planetary and human	Eco-system restoration and health co-benefits	Humphrey Agevi, ARIN Ayub Macharia, NEMA

		well-being. This track quantifies and qualifies these connections and will explore how conservation, nature-based solutions, equitable benefit-sharing, biocultural approaches, ecosystem services, and green/blue economy transitions contribute to improved public health outcomes.		
Track 5	Equity, Ethics, Justice, and Inclusive Adaptation in the Environment–Climate–Health Nexus	Climate change deepens existing inequities for marginalized and underserved groups. This track invites research studies that examine these disparities and bring these voices to the forefront, and offer justice-focused solutions.	Climate change and inequalities Partnerships with indigenous communities/groups Gender sensitive approaches Disability inclusive adaptation Equity and ethical frameworks	Julian Natukunda, CHANCE Eurallyah Akinyi, ARIN
Track 6	Governance, Leadership, Cross-Sector Collaboration, and Policy for Integrated Environment- Climate change and Health action	Building climate resilience in health means dismantling silos and forging new alliances. We especially welcome governance models, integrated	Policy integration of health in climate action Climate-health governance innovations Cross-sector	Joanes Atela, ARIN AMREF- tbc?

		strategies, and case studies that enable coordinated, multi-stakeholder efforts for greater climate resilience.	collaboration & leadership models decentralised climate-health governance	
Track 7	Climate Finance for Health and Environmental Adaptation and Resilience	What strategies can bolster the economic justification for health-focused climate adaptation? This track explores applications of economic analysis, cost–benefit modelling, and novel financing instruments. We also invite studies on tapping and maximizing climate finance to enhance health system resilience and adaptive capacity.	Economic assessments of climate-health interventions. Cost-benefit and cost-effectiveness studies. Estimates of pocket expenses for health care and other impacts of extreme weather.	Gerishom Gimaiyo, Rockefeller Foundation
Track 8	Land Use, Urbanization, and Built Environments in a Changing Climate for Healthy Cities	Urbanization and shifting land use patterns reshape health risks in the face of climate change. Submissions can explore how planning, design, urban governance, and infrastructure can foster healthier, more climate-resilient cities. This includes examining	Urban heat stress and green spaces climate vulnerability in informal settlements Urban health planning and climate resilience	James Mwitari, KEMRI Jusper Omwenga, NEMA

In addition, we will have capacity-building workshops for science-policy translation, climate literacy, indigenous knowledge, climate

financing, etc., prioritizing researchers, policymakers, community-based organizations, and other relevant stakeholders. We will also include networking and several interactive sessions, which have been extremely successful at previous events.

Pre- and Post-Conference Activities:

We will host a series of activities to build momentum before the conference, such as track-specific webinars. And we will follow up on discussions and resolutions taken at the conference. This includes ongoing support for communities of practice established during the conference and coordinating with planned regional science-policy hubs and centers of excellence. We will also support activities post-conference that promote networking ahead of the UNFCCC COP30 meeting in Brazil in October.

The following are examples of planned pre- and post-conference activities:

a. Mazingira Day Tree Planting & Nature Restoration Campaign (October 10th) - This flagship pre-conference activity will bring together conference delegates, youth groups, community leaders, local health workers, and government representatives to plant trees and restore green spaces in a selected Kenyan region

b. Pre- and Post-conference webinars jointly led by all convenors and aligned to the key tracks to set the scene for the event and build common ground ahead of time. Follow up on conference commitments, leveraging the CHANCE platform, CAPCHA, ARIN Friday reviews.

c. Virtual climate-health post-conference policy labs leveraging all partners' convening platforms for multi-stakeholder dialogues, workshops, and tech hackathons on innovative solutions for climate and health issues in Africa.

Expected Outputs

1. A State of Evidence on Africa's Environment, Climate change and Health 2025 report that evaluates successes, gaps, and lessons learned to be shared with all participants, uploaded on CAPCHA, CHANCE, and other online platforms for wider reach. A proposal to publish it under Taylor and Francis / AAS KEMRI's African Journal
2. Strengthened Environment, Climate and Health Partnerships for the Actualization of Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs) and COP commitments
3. Research and practice compendium (collection of research, case studies, and best practices presented at the conference). A proposal to publish it under Taylor and Francis / AAS KEMRI's African Journal
4. Creation of virtual labs fostering coordination beyond the conference.

5. Conference Reports and Call to Action.

Conference speakers

We will have a three-tiered approach to inviting conference speakers

Tier 1

We will have a call for expression of interest to researchers, leveraging the ARIN database to ensure a diverse and high-quality selection of presentations that align with the conference's objectives. The call will aim to assess progress in Enviornment, Climate Change and Health research, fostering engagement across different levels of stakeholders.

Tier 2

We will invite leading policymakers active in climate, environment and health policy development, leveraging the CHANCE network system that is linked to Government Ministries. We will also leverage WHO Afro and AMREF platform for a wider African reach.

Tier 3

We will reach out to other partners beyond researchers and policymakers within the Environment, climate change and health ecosystem to participate in the conference, e.g. Indigenous Knowledge Systems Partners.

A **Scientific Committee** will be established from the conference committee, comprising experts from all convening and key partner institutions and donors. The committee will have track leads who will be tasked with reviewing submissions, ensuring relevance, and maintaining academic and policy rigor.

Expression of interest submissions will be done through an online conference submission portal and managed by a dedicated, centralized conference administrative secretariat. The secretariat will streamline expressions of interest and invitations from other tiers and facilitate communication with applicants to ensure transparency in the selection process.

All policymakers will be sponsored to attend the event, considering resource constraints in most governments. Speakers who will be identified to share their work and are unable to cover their travel costs will also be supported. Lastly, participants from community-based organizations or those implementing environment, climate, and health work at the grassroots level will also be sponsored to attend. The rest of the delegates will fund their travel and accommodation as they have done so at previous conferences.

Conference Partnerships and Collaborations

Core Partners: CHANCE Network and ARIN in collaboration with the Ministry of Health, Ministry of Environment, Climate Change, and Forestry, KEMRI, NEMA, and AMREF

(Organizations represented under CHANCE through the steering committee include the University of Botswana, Wits RHI, the London School of Hygiene and Tropical Medicine, the

Aga Khan University, the CICERO Center for International Climate Research, the Foundation for Professional Development, and the African Population and Health Research Center)

Tentative conference committee: AMREF Health Africa; Ministry of Health; Health Systems Global (Thematic Working Group on Climate-Resilient Health Systems); Science for Africa Foundation; Africa Climate and Health Alliance; Global Consortium for Climate and Health Education; Pan-African Climate Justice Alliance (PACJA)

Other key stakeholders: Global Climate and Health Alliance; African Institute for Development Policy (AFIDEP); International Association of National Public Health Institutes (IANPHI); Global Heat Health Information Network; Association of Schools of Public Health in Africa (ASPHA); Regional Science-Policy Hub Directors (TBC); Resurgence; Kounkey Design Initiative, Africa Community of Planetary Partners for Health and Environment (ACOPPHE)

Agencies: WHO-AFRO ClimHealth; ATACH; Africa CDC, WHO-EGU

Donors and Climate Financiers: Wellcome Trust, European Union, Rockefeller Foundation, International Development Research Center, Green Climate Fund, Adaptation Fund and others (TBC)

Pre-conference Milestones

- Conference launch: *30 May 2025*
- Confirm scientific track chairs: *06 June 2025*
- Registration and Abstract submission opens: *09 June 2025*
- Abstract submission deadline: *11 July 2025*
- Abstract review complete: *25 July 2025*
- Invitations to keynote speakers and chairs: *30 July 2025*
- Confirmations sent for oral presentations for science tracks: *30 July 2025*
- Conference logistics finalised: *15 August 2025*
- Registration deadline: *30 September 2025*
- Hosting of conference: *21-24 October 2025*
- Post conference debriefing: *05 November 2025*
- Peer review of conference report: *28 November 2025*
- Finalisation of conference report: *January 2026*
- Dissemination of conference report: *February 2026*

Conference Location and Venue

The conference will be held in Nairobi, Kenya, at Emara Ole Sereni. Nairobi is a strategic location and gateway to East Africa. It has an international airport, world-class conference venues, accommodations, and several tourist sites, including National Parks and museums. Kenya also has experience in hosting climate and health conferences. These include the 3rd Kenya Health and Climate Change Conference held in Machakos County in October 2024 and the Kenya Innovation Week (climate-health theme). Other climate and health initiatives led by Kenya include the following:

- Active participation in regional climate initiatives - Kenya has previously hosted the Africa Climate Summit and the 11th Conference on Climate Change and Development in Africa (CCDA-XI) in 2023.
- Commitment to Integrating Climate Evidence into Health Strategies - Kenya is currently preparing to launch its national Climate and Health Strategy (2024-2029)

- An extensive and rich network of research institutions and stakeholders (ARIN, KEMRI, Universities, AMREF)

We expect a diverse, transdisciplinary, and international audience of approximately 500–800 participants, with strong representation from across Africa and select global partners.

Target Participants Include:

- Researchers and Academics: Climate scientists, public health experts, environmental researchers, social scientists, and economists presenting cutting-edge research.
- Policy Makers and Government Representatives: International, Regional, National, and local officials from Ministries of Health, Environment, Finance, and Planning, particularly from African countries.
- Civil Society and Community Leaders: Indigenous knowledge holders, youth activists, grassroots organizations, and NGOs working on the frontlines of climate change and health.
- Healthcare Professionals: Public health officers, doctors, nurses, and health system managers engaged in climate adaptation or disaster response.
- Development Partners and Donors: Representatives from UN agencies, bilateral donors, and multilateral development banks investing in environment, health, and climate resilience.
- Private Sector Stakeholders: Innovators, climate-smart tech companies, health startups, insurers, and urban developers with solutions or interest in climate-health collaboration.
- Journalists and Media Professionals: Especially those focused on science communication, climate reporting, and public interest storytelling.
- Youth and Students: Young climate-health advocates, early-career researchers, and university students through scholarships, art contests, or youth townhalls.